

The Ceasefire That Died

The US-Iran memorandum of understanding signed just three weeks ago collapsed this week after Iran attacked commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, triggering three rounds of US strikes and an Iranian declaration closing the waterway entirely. NATO fractured in Ankara, Le Pen launched a presidential campaign under a corruption conviction, climate-driven disasters killed dozens across three continents, and China landed a reusable rocket for the first time.

The MoU Is Dead: How the US-Iran Ceasefire Unraveled in One Week

The memorandum of understanding that ended the US-Israel-Iran war on June 17 lasted less than a month. The breakdown began on Monday when three commercial tankers — including Qatari and Saudi-flagged vessels — were attacked in or near the Strait of Hormuz. The US responded on Tuesday with strikes on over 80 Iranian targets, hitting IRGC small boats, air defence systems, and coastal radar. Iran's IRGC retaliated with missile and drone attacks on US military sites in Bahrain and Kuwait. A second round of US strikes hit Chabahar and the IRGC Navy's Imam Ali base on Wednesday, with Iranian media reporting explosions in Konarak, Bandar Abbas, and on disputed islands. By Thursday, Trump declared the ceasefire 'over,' calling Iran's leaders 'scum' and telling reporters: 'Every time they hit us, we're going to hit them 20.' At least 17 people were killed and 115 wounded across the exchange. By Saturday, the escalation had reached its most dangerous point yet: Iran's IRGC fired a naval cruise missile at the Cyprus-flagged MV GFS Galaxy, forced its crew to abandon ship, and declared the Strait of Hormuz closed until further notice. US Central Command launched a third round of strikes. Iran's new Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei — in his first public statement since assuming power — called for vengeance for his father's assassination, calling it 'the will of the nation.' Trump warned that any assassination attempt on him would trigger the US to 'decimate and destroy all areas' of Iran. Yet diplomacy has not entirely stopped. US officials told American media that Iranian counterparts privately acknowledged the tanker attacks were a 'mistake' by a rogue hardline faction. Qatari mediators visited Tehran, and Iranian Foreign Minister Araghchi travelled to Oman for further talks. The US delegation for Saturday's negotiations in Oman includes Vice-President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, and Jared Kushner. But the gap between what Iran calls a 'safe route' through Hormuz and what Washington considers free passage may be narrowing to a point of no return.

Why it matters:

The MoU's collapse was always foreseeable — its vague language on Hormuz was the deal's weakest point. But the speed and intensity of the unraveling, culminating in an outright closure declaration, has turned a diplomatic process into a military standoff with no obvious off-ramp. One-fifth of global oil and LNG passes through Hormuz in peacetime. The world is now dealing with a controlled chokepoint, not a contested waterway.

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Hormuz Choked: From 130 Ships a Day to 23

The numbers tell the story of the strait's near-paralysis. Before the war, 130 to 138 ships transited the Strait of Hormuz daily. By Wednesday of this week, maritime intelligence firm Kpler recorded just 23 crossings. The US-backed Omani southern route, which had peaked at 28 ships per day in late June, saw zero transits after three tankers were attacked on it earlier in the week. Phil Belcher of Intertanko, the international tanker owners' association, said ships using the southern route were now in 'single figures.' Brent crude surged as much as 7 percent on Wednesday, topping \$79 a barrel before settling at \$78.76 — still well below the near-\$120 highs during the war's peak, but a sharp reversal from the pre-MoU settlement of \$72.48. The US Strategic Petroleum Reserve fell to 319.5 million barrels, its lowest level since 1983, after drawdowns that began in March. Iran has established a 'Persian Gulf Strait Authority' to control authorized transit and impose what Fars news agency described as 'service fees.' The IMO's governing council 'strongly condemned' Iran's sovereignty claim over the strait, calling on its 176 member states not to recognize any Iranian decisions aimed at 'closing, obstructing, hampering or otherwise interfering with international navigation.' The IMF, which cut its 2026 global growth forecast to 3 percent this week, acknowledged that its baseline assumes Hormuz reopens by mid-July and returns to pre-war levels by March 2027 — an assumption that now looks tenuous at best. Market analyst Fabien Yip of IG noted that oil's brief return to near pre-war levels 'suggested markets were leaning on a best-case outcome' for the MoU, and that 'this week's re-escalation is a reminder of how fragile that assumption was.'

Why it matters:

The Hormuz closure is not just an energy story — it is a test of whether international law and coalition enforcement can keep the world's most critical waterway open. Iran is betting that calibrated military pressure combined with continued diplomacy gives it leverage. The IMF's growth forecast, the SPR at 42-year lows, and the near-zero traffic on the Omani route all point to an energy system with dangerously thin buffers.

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NATO in Ankara: Billions Pledged, Alliances Fractured

NATO's two-day summit in Ankara produced headline commitments — £37bn (\$50bn) for a Deep Precision Strike missile programme, €70bn (\$80bn) in military assistance for Ukraine, and a commitment to sustain at least equivalent levels in 2027. Norway pledged 3 billion crowns (\$306m) specifically for Ukraine's air defences. NATO also announced it would replace its ageing AWACS fleet with Sweden's GlobeEye aircraft, and Airbus secured a large contract for new transport aircraft. But the summit was dominated by Trump, who told reporters he only attended because it was hosted by 'my friend' Erdogan. He lashed out at European allies for refusing to join the Iran war, singled out Spain as 'a wasted cause,' and instructed Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent to 'cut it off' from trade. He repeated his assertion that the US should take over Greenland, calling it territory that 'should be controlled by the United States.' Only five of NATO's 32 members are projected to meet the 3.5% GDP core defence spending target in 2026. Trump also rewarded Turkey, lifting CAATSA sanctions imposed for Ankara's purchase of Russian S-400 systems and saying he would 'consider' resuming F-35 fighter jet sales. The move drew opposition from Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu, who said it would 'upset the power balance in the Middle East,' but Republican Senator Lindsey Graham said he was open to a solution. NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte defended the Iran strikes as 'absolutely necessary' and insisted the alliance was unified — a claim that looked increasingly hollow as Trump attacked two members and embraced an autocrat who bought Russian air defences.

Why it matters:

The summit showed NATO can mobilize serious resources while simultaneously being undermined by its most powerful member. The £37bn missile programme and €70bn Ukraine commitment are real money, but Trump's attacks on Spain, his Greenland remarks, and his sanctions lift for Turkey signal that the alliance's biggest fracture runs between Washington and Europe, not between NATO and its adversaries.

Ukraine's Dual Campaign: Patriot Diplomacy and Drone Lockdown

Ukraine pressed its case on two fronts this week. At the NATO summit, Zelensky met Trump, who offered Ukraine a licence to manufacture Patriot interceptor missiles — a response to Kyiv's urgent plea after the Ukrainian Air Force reported that none of the 23 ballistic missiles Russia fired on Sunday night were intercepted, killing more than 20 people. The licence is symbolic for now: Patriot missiles are extremely complex, and no part of Ukrainian territory is safe from Russian strikes. Former security officer Ivan Stupak told the BBC production would more likely take place on European soil. On the battlefield, Ukraine's drone forces struck at least 25 Russian ships over four days in the Sea of Azov, targeting Russia's 'shadow fleet' of commercial oil tankers. Two tankers in Taganrog Bay were still burning on Thursday. The strikes coincide with Ukraine's continued attacks on Russian oil refineries and fuel depots, with hits confirmed in Tver, Stavropol, and Rostov regions. Russia has banned diesel exports, and over 90 percent of its regions are experiencing fuel rationing or shortages. Russian military bloggers called the tankers a 'shooting gallery' for Ukrainian drone operators, while the Black Sea Fleet 'shut itself in at Novorossiysk.' Putin addressed fuel shortages on state TV, insisting the situation was 'not critical' while his government subsidised prices and authorised lower-grade fuel sales. Russia escalated its own drone campaign against Zaporizhzhia, using 'mothership' drones that release multiple smaller FPV drones and mesh networking technology that makes them harder to jam. Ukraine intercepted 884 Russian drones in the last week of June alone. Russian territorial gains have collapsed from 2,190 sq km in the first half of 2025 to a net gain of just 97 sq km this year, while Ukraine estimates Russia suffered 39,490 casualties in June — far exceeding estimated monthly recruitment capacity.

Why it matters:

Ukraine is executing a 'logistics lockdown' strategy that combines naval drones targeting Russia's maritime supply lines with refinery strikes squeezing its domestic fuel. The question is whether the cumulative pressure translates into territorial gains or negotiating leverage. Russia's shift to mothership drones shows it is also adapting, and the Patriot licence — while welcome — is months from producing actual interceptors.

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Le Pen Defies Conviction to Launch Presidential Bid

Marine Le Pen confirmed she will run for the French presidency in 2027 just hours after a Paris appeals court upheld her guilty verdict for embezzling public funds. The court reduced her ban on holding public office from five years to one — a modification that allows her to campaign while she appeals to the Court of Cassation. The one-year ban with an electronic tag is suspended during the appeal, which could stretch into early 2027. Le Pen proposed a duo: herself as president and 30-year-old Jordan Bardella as prime minister. Polls show Bardella polling marginally ahead of her at above 30% for the first round. Opponents criticized the decision: former PM Gabriel Attal noted the 'moral dimension' of running despite a conviction for embezzling public funds, while right-wing Republicans secretary-general Othman Nasrou called it 'yet another reversal that damages the French people's trust in politics.' Conservative candidate Bruno Retailleau quipped that after a 40-year-old president, the French would 'certainly adore having a president of 30.' The stakes extend beyond France. Le Pen and Bardella are Eurosceptic and sceptical of both NATO and military support for Ukraine. A Le Pen presidency would shift France's posture on European security at a moment when the continent is rearming in response to Russia. The first round is set for 18 April 2027.

Why it matters:

A convicted embezzler running for president under a potential electronic tag is without precedent in a major European democracy. The court's decision to shorten Le Pen's ban — rather than uphold it — gave her the opening she needed. If she wins, France's position on NATO, Ukraine, and EU defence coordination would shift dramatically, with consequences for the entire European security order.

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Climate Disasters on Three Continents: Spain, China, and the Philippines

A wildfire in Almería, southeastern Spain, has killed at least 12 people — including four British nationals — with 23 still missing, making it one of Spain's deadliest fires in decades. Andalusia's emergencies minister called it 'the most devastating fire' the region has ever seen. The blaze, attributed to a fallen power line, burned 6,600 hectares amid sustained 40°C heat. In France, more than 10,000 people were evacuated from the Pyrenees foothills, and Interior Minister Laurent Nuñez said 32 people had been arrested on suspicion of starting fires. In East Asia, Super Typhoon Bavi — spanning 1,000 km at its widest, roughly the width of France — killed at least 17 people in the Philippines before making landfall in China's Zhejiang province, forcing 1.7 million evacuations. It struck just days after Typhoon Maysak killed at least 39 people in Guangxi and Hubei and spawned rare inland tornadoes. China's President Xi ordered 'all-out' rescue operations. Bavi also battered Guam and the Northern Mariana Islands, where residents were still recovering from April's Super Typhoon Sinlaku, which killed 17 and caused approximately \$1.5bn in damage. The pattern is stark: 11 category four or five tropical cyclones have hit US territories in the past decade — one more than the total recorded in the prior 57 years. Europe is warming twice as fast as the global average, per Copernicus. Last year, a record 393,000 hectares burned in Spain — more than six times the 2006-2024 average. These are no longer isolated events; they are converging systems failure.

Why it matters:

Three simultaneous climate-driven crises — wildfire in Spain, back-to-back super typhoons in East Asia, heatwave across Southern Europe — produced casualties this week that rival armed conflicts. The scale of civilian harm, including foreign nationals among the dead, turns these from environmental events into political and public safety crises that existing emergency response capacity is struggling to match.

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Trump Empties Election Commission, Subpoenas NYT Reporters

Two moves this week tightened the administration's grip on democratic institutions and press scrutiny. Trump removed the last remaining members of the Election Assistance Commission — the independent federal body that certifies voting systems and maintains the national mail voter registration form. The two Democratic appointees were fired by email; the sole Republican resigned; a fourth commissioner had already left in April. The EAC had previously declined to implement part of Trump's March 2025 executive order requiring proof of citizenship on the national mail voter registration form — a requirement a federal judge later ruled exceeded presidential authority. The commission is now entirely empty four months before midterm elections. Separately, the Justice Department issued federal grand jury subpoenas to several New York Times journalists over their reporting on security concerns surrounding the president's new Air Force One plane — a Boeing 747-8 gifted by Qatar valued at roughly \$400 million. The Times had reported that the Secret Service urged Trump to switch planes on his return from the NATO summit, citing inadequate antimissile capabilities. Times newsroom lawyer David McCraw called the subpoenas a 'brazen act' designed to intimidate journalists. The DOJ said the investigation targets 'those leaking classified information, not reporters.' Both moves follow the Supreme Court's 6-3 ruling last month expanding presidential removal power over independent agencies — a decision that effectively removed the legal barrier Trump needed to hollow out the EAC. The reporters are required to appear before a grand jury in Manhattan on Wednesday.

Why it matters:

An empty election commission four months before midterms and grand jury subpoenas targeting national security reporters in the same week are not coincidental. They represent a systematic narrowing of the institutional checks — bipartisan election oversight and press accountability — that constrain executive power. The Supreme Court's expansion of presidential removal authority has removed the structural barrier that made these moves legally difficult.

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Syria Delisted, Macron Bombed, China Reaches Space

The US announced it will remove Syria from the state sponsor of terrorism list after 47 years, effective in 45 days unless Congress blocks the move. Secretary of State Rubio cited 'formal assurances' from President Ahmed al-Sharaa. Trump, meeting al-Sharaa at the NATO summit, said he was 'doing an unbelievable job in unifying Syria.' Only Iran, North Korea, and Cuba will remain on the list. The delisting removes the primary legal barrier to international investment in Syria's reconstruction. But the country remains deeply unstable: two bomb explosions near the Four Seasons hotel in Damascus injured 18 people during Macron's visit — the first by a Western European leader since Assad's fall — and a separate bomb at a Damascus cafe killed at least 10. France's Le Pen verdict was not the only earthquake in French politics this week. Macron's Damascus visit was meant to signal Western re-engagement with post-Assad Syria; instead, it underscored how fragile security remains. The 15 bilateral agreements signed on civil aviation, health, and banking will proceed, but the bombings demonstrated that even a heavily guarded presidential perimeter can be penetrated. Meanwhile, China successfully landed a reusable orbital-class rocket booster for the first time on Friday. The Long March 10B used a net-catching mechanism on a floating platform — different from SpaceX's propulsive landing but achieving the same objective. Shares in Chinese space firms jumped 10%. China is now the third entity to demonstrate reusable orbital rocket recovery, after SpaceX and Blue Origin, narrowing a gap that determines access to satellite infrastructure, space-based intelligence, and eventual deep-space operations.

Why it matters:

The Syria delisting is a calculated bet that al-Sharaa can stabilize a shattered country — and a signal to Israel that Washington's priorities have shifted. The Damascus bombings are a reminder that the bet is far from won. And China's reusable rocket milestone, while less dramatic than the week's military escalations, marks a structural shift in the strategic competition for access to space.

The Bottom Line

A week that began with Khamenei's funeral and ended with Iran closing the Strait of Hormuz. The US-Iran ceasefire — the diplomatic centrepiece of the post-war order — is functionally dead after three rounds of US strikes, Iranian retaliation across Gulf states, and a declaration shutting the world's most critical energy waterway. Daily ship transits through Hormuz fell from 130 to 23; the US Strategic Petroleum Reserve is at a 42-year low. At NATO in Ankara, allies pledged £37bn for missiles and €70bn for Ukraine while Trump attacked Spain, lifted sanctions on Turkey, and revived his Greenland ambition. Le Pen launched a presidential campaign under a corruption conviction. Climate disasters killed dozens across three continents. Trump emptied the election commission and subpoenaed NYT reporters. China landed a reusable rocket. The institutions designed to manage this instability — ceasefires, alliances, election oversight, press freedom — are being tested simultaneously, and most are fraying.